WEEK 6: RELATIONSHIPS, ATTACHMENT & INTIMACY

Attachment Theory Basics

How you relate to others sexually and emotionally didn't start in adulthood. Your attachment patterns formed in early childhood and shape every relationship you have.

Attachment theory explains:

- How you bond (or don't) with others
- What you expect from relationships
- How you respond to intimacy and vulnerability
- Why you might use sex to avoid or create connection

THE FOUR ATTACHMENT STYLES:

1. SECURE ATTACHMENT

What it looks like:

- Comfortable with intimacy and independence
- Can express needs and emotions clearly
- Trusts others and yourself
- Handles conflict without shutting down or escalating
- Sex is connected to emotional intimacy

How it developed: Consistent, responsive caregiving in childhood. Your needs were met reliably.

---

2. ANXIOUS ATTACHMENT

What it looks like:

- Fear of abandonment or rejection
- Constant need for reassurance
- Hyper-vigilant to signs of disconnection

- May use sex to maintain connection or prove worth
- Difficulty being alone

How it developed: Inconsistent caregiving. Sometimes your needs were met, sometimes ignored.

In CSBD: May use sexual behavior to feel wanted, to manage anxiety about relationships, or to avoid feeling abandoned.

---

3. AVOIDANT ATTACHMENT

What it looks like:

- Uncomfortable with emotional closeness
- Values independence over connection
- Difficulty expressing emotions or needs
- May use sex as substitute for emotional intimacy
- Pulls away when relationships get "too close"

How it developed: Caregivers were emotionally unavailable or dismissive of your needs.

In CSBD: May use anonymous sex, pornography, or fantasy to avoid the vulnerability of real intimacy.

---

4. DISORGANIZED ATTACHMENT

What it looks like:

- Conflicted—want closeness but fear it
- Unpredictable relationship patterns
- May sabotage relationships
- Trauma history often present
- Sex may be tied to fear, pain, or confusion

How it developed: Caregivers were frightening or abusive. The person who should provide safety was also the source of fear.

In CSBD: May use sexual behavior to manage trauma responses, to self-soothe after relational pain, or to recreate familiar patterns.

EXERCISE 1: ATTACHMENT STYLE ASSESSMENT

Read each statement and mark how true it is for you:

1 = Not true at all | 2 = Somewhat true | 3 = Moderately true | 4 = Very true | 5 = Extremely true

---

SECURE ATTACHMENT INDICATORS:

- ☐ I find it easy to get emotionally close to others _____
- ☐ I'm comfortable depending on others and having others depend on me _____
- ☐ I don't worry much about being abandoned or rejected _____
- ☐ I can communicate my needs clearly in relationships _____
- ☐ I'm comfortable with both intimacy and independence _____

Total Secure Score: _____

ANXIOUS ATTACHMENT INDICATORS:

- ☐ I worry that others don't really care about me _____
- ☐ I need a lot of reassurance that I'm loved _____
- ☐ I'm afraid people will leave me _____
- ☐ I get very upset when relationships feel distant _____
- ☐ I often feel I love my partner more than they love me _____

Total Anxious Score: _____

AVOIDANT ATTACHMENT INDICATORS:

- ☐ I prefer not to depend on others or have others depend on me _____
- ☐ I'm uncomfortable when relationships get too close _____
- ☐ I find it difficult to trust others completely _____
- ☐ Partners often want me to be more emotionally open than I'm comfortable with _____
- ☐ I value my independence more than my relationships _____

Total Avoidant Score: _____

DISORGANIZED ATTACHMENT INDICATORS:

- ☐ I want close relationships but I'm afraid of getting hurt _____
- ☐ My feelings about relationships are confusing to me _____

- [ ] I sometimes push people away even though I don't want to _____
- [ ] I've experienced trauma or abuse in my past _____
- [ ] My relationships feel chaotic or unpredictable _____

Total Disorganized Score: _____

My highest score is in: _____

What this means for my recovery:

_____

_____

_____

_____

Intimacy vs. Intensity

One of the most important distinctions in recovery: **Intimacy is not the same as intensity.**

Many men with CSBD confuse the two.

INTIMACY: KNOWING AND BEING KNOWN

What it is:

- Emotional connection
- Vulnerability and honesty
- Being seen for who you really are
- Mutual understanding
- Trust built over time
- Feeling safe to be yourself

What it feels like:

- Calm, grounded, peaceful
- Safe
- Warm
- Requires patience

- Builds slowly

What it requires:

- Honesty about who you are
- Emotional risk
- Time and consistency
- Reciprocity
- Showing up even when it's boring

INTENSITY: EXCITEMENT AND NOVELTY

What it is:

- High arousal and excitement
- Novelty and newness
- The "high" of pursuit or conquest
- Drama or risk
- Fantasy and idealization
- Dopamine-driven

What it feels like:

- Electrifying, thrilling
- Urgent
- Consuming
- Requires constant stimulation
- Burns out quickly

What it requires:

- Newness (which always fades)
- Distance (mystery, unavailability)
- Risk or taboo
- Fantasy (not seeing the real person)

- Avoidance of the mundane

WHY THIS MATTERS:

Compulsive sexual behavior is driven by **intensity**, not intimacy.

- Anonymous encounters = High intensity, zero intimacy
- Pornography = High intensity, zero intimacy
- Affairs = High intensity (at first), shallow intimacy
- Pursuing unavailable people = High intensity, low intimacy

The problem: Intensity feels like connection in the moment, but it leaves you more alone. Intimacy feels less exciting, but it actually fills the need.

Recovery means: Learning to tolerate (and eventually value) the slower, deeper, less dramatic experience of real intimacy.

EXERCISE 2: INTIMACY VS. INTENSITY IN MY LIFE

Where have I sought intensity instead of intimacy?

_____

_____

_____

What does intensity give me that intimacy doesn't?

_____

_____

What does intimacy give me that intensity doesn't?

_____

_____

How has my pursuit of intensity affected my capacity for intimacy?

_____

_____

_____

What would it mean to choose intimacy over intensity?

_____

Common Relationship Patterns in CSBD

CSBD doesn't just affect you—it affects every relationship you have.

PATTERN #1: USING SEX TO AVOID EMOTIONAL INTIMACY

What it looks like:

- Sex is the primary (or only) form of connection
- You pursue sex but avoid emotional conversation
- You're more comfortable with physical closeness than emotional vulnerability
- After emotional intimacy attempts, you act out

Why it happens:

- Emotional intimacy feels scarier than sexual intimacy
- Sex is familiar; vulnerability is terrifying
- You don't have the skills for emotional connection

The cost:

- Your partner feels used or objectified
- You never experience true intimacy
- The relationship stays shallow

PATTERN #2: FANTASY AS SUBSTITUTE FOR REAL CONNECTION

What it looks like:

- Pornography or fantasy relationships feel safer than real ones
- You prefer the "perfect" fantasy person to the imperfect real person
- You compare real partners to fantasy and find them lacking
- You withdraw from real relationships into fantasy

Why it happens:

- Fantasy is controllable; real people aren't
- Fantasy never disappoints, rejects, or requires effort
- You can avoid the messiness of real relationships

The cost:

- Real relationships can never compete with fantasy
- You become increasingly isolated
- You lose capacity for authentic connection

PATTERN #3: SEXUAL ACTING OUT AFTER INTIMACY ATTEMPTS

What it looks like:

- After a good date or meaningful conversation, you act out
- When your partner is vulnerable with you, you pull away sexually
- Emotional closeness triggers sexual compulsivity

Why it happens:

- Intimacy creates anxiety (especially for avoidant attachment)
- Vulnerability feels dangerous
- Acting out is a way to create distance and regain control

The cost:

- You sabotage the very connection you claim to want
- Your partner feels confused and hurt
- The relationship can't deepen

PATTERN #4: BETRAYAL TRAUMA FOR PARTNERS

What it looks like:

- Your partner experiences symptoms similar to PTSD
- They can't trust you (even when you're telling the truth)
- They become hypervigilant, checking your devices, monitoring you

- The relationship becomes parent-child instead of partners

Why it happens:

- Discovery of sexual behavior is traumatic
- Trust has been shattered, often multiple times
- Your partner feels unsafe in the relationship

The cost:

- Both of you suffer
- The relationship may not survive
- Even if it does, healing takes years

EXERCISE 3: HOW CSBD HAS AFFECTED MY RELATIONSHIPS

Be honest. This is hard to look at, but necessary.

How has my sexual behavior damaged my primary relationship (if applicable)?

_____

_____

_____

_____

How has it affected my friendships?

_____

_____

_____

How has it affected my family relationships?

_____

_____

_____

What trust have I broken?

_____

_____

_____

What lies have I told?

_____

_____

_____

Who has been hurt by my behavior?

_____

_____

_____

What amends do I need to make (if any)?

_____

_____

_____

_____

What Would a Healthy Intimate Relationship Look Like?

Many men with CSBD have never experienced healthy intimacy. You might not even know what it looks like.

Healthy intimate relationships include:

EMOTIONAL SAFETY

- You can be yourself without fear of judgment
- Conflict doesn't mean the relationship is over
- You can express needs without shame
- Vulnerability is met with care, not exploitation

HONEST COMMUNICATION

- You can say hard things
- You listen to understand, not to defend
- You can disagree without being disagreeable
- Both people can say "no" without fear

MUTUAL RESPECT

- You value each other's autonomy

- You don't try to control or change each other
- Differences are accepted
- Boundaries are honored

TRUST

- Consistency between words and actions
- Reliability over time
- Honesty even when it's hard
- Accountability when trust is broken

RECIPROCITY

- Both people give and receive
- Both people's needs matter
- Effort is mutual
- Neither person carries the whole relationship

SEXUAL CONNECTION (when applicable)

- Sex is an expression of intimacy, not a substitute for it
- Both people's desires and boundaries matter
- Communication about sex is open
- Sex enhances the relationship rather than being the only connection

---

EXERCISE 4: MY VISION FOR HEALTHY INTIMACY

What would a healthy intimate relationship look like for me?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

What qualities do I want in a partner?

_____

What qualities do I need to develop in myself?

What fears do I have about real intimacy?

What would I need to change to be capable of healthy intimacy?

Healthy Intimacy Skills Preview

Building capacity for intimacy requires skills. Here are the core ones you'll need:

1. EMOTIONAL AWARENESS

- Recognizing what you're feeling
- Understanding why you're feeling it
- Expressing feelings in words

2. VULNERABILITY

- Sharing who you really are
- Admitting when you're wrong
- Asking for what you need
- Letting someone see your struggles

3. ACTIVE LISTENING

- Hearing without planning your response

- Reflecting back what you heard
- Asking clarifying questions
- Being curious instead of defensive

4. CONFLICT RESOLUTION

- Staying present during disagreement
- Using "I" statements
- Taking responsibility for your part
- Repairing after conflict

5. SETTING BOUNDARIES

- Knowing what's okay and what's not
- Saying "no" without guilt
- Respecting others' "no"
- Protecting your own wellbeing

6. ASKING FOR NEEDS

- Knowing what you need
- Believing you deserve to have needs
- Asking directly instead of hinting
- Accepting that you won't always get what you need

EXERCISE 5: INTIMACY SKILLS PRACTICE

This week, practice ONE of these skills with a safe person (friend, family member, therapist).

Which skill will I practice? _____

With whom? _____

What will I do specifically?

_____

_____

_____

How did it go?

_____

_____

_____

What did I learn?

_____

_____

_____

What was difficult?

_____

_____

_____

DAILY MONITORING LOG - WEEK 6

Continue your daily monitoring. This week, add focus on relationships and intimacy.

Additional tracking:

- How did I avoid intimacy this week?
- When did I choose intensity over intimacy?
- Did I practice any intimacy skills?

[7 daily logs with same format as previous weeks—see Appendix A for blank forms]

WEEK 6 HOMEWORK CHECKLIST

Before moving to Week 7, complete:

- [ ] Read all Week 6 material
- [ ] Complete attachment style assessment
- [ ] Complete "Intimacy vs. Intensity in My Life" exercise
- [ ] Reflect on how CSBD has affected your relationships
- [ ] Write your vision for healthy intimacy
- [ ] Practice one intimacy skill with a safe person
- [ ] Complete daily monitoring logs for all 7 days
- [ ] Notice: How do I avoid emotional intimacy? What triggers my avoidance?

Notes for Week 6:

END OF WEEK 6